

Lesson One - The Pulse:

Quarter Notes, Quarter Rests, and Half Rests

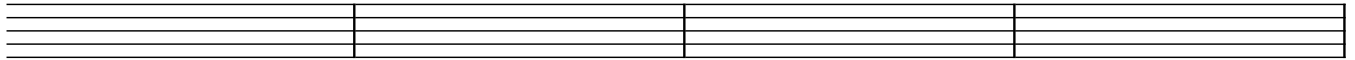
Jacobo Vega-Albela

What is the pulse?

The **pulse** is the heartbeat of a piece of music. It is what you nod your head or tap your foot to when you hear a song. The pulse serves as the rhythmic framework to which we relate everything we play. One unit of the pulse is called a **beat**, and these beats are spaced uniformly in time.

What is a Measure/Bar?

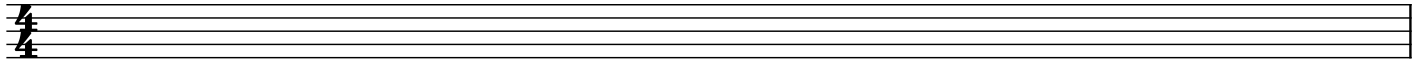
We organize music into **measures** or **bars**; longer units of musical time made up of several beats. In music notation, measures/bars are separated by measure lines (also called bar lines). The terms “measure” and “bar” will be used interchangeably. Here you can see four empty measures:



What is a Time Signature?

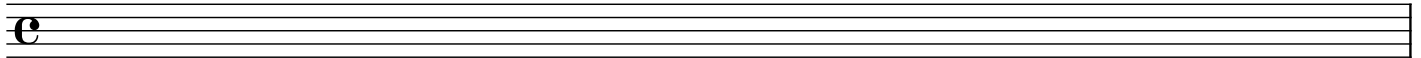
A **time signature** gives us information about how the measures we are looking at are organized. Time signatures are made up of two numbers, sort of like fractions. The most common time signature in Western music is 4/4. It is so common that it is sometimes called **common time**. It looks like this in a piece of music:

5



Or you may see this shorthand for **common time** (interchangeable with 4/4).

6



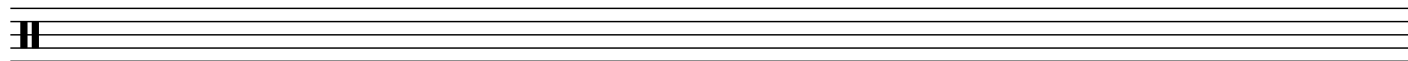
2

Each number in our time signature gives us a different piece of information. The **number on top** tells us *how many beats in each measure*. The **number on the bottom** tells us *what type of note gets the beat, or how we are representing our pulse* (this will make more sense later).

What is a clef?

A clef tells us how to interpret the lines and spaces of the staff. We will use the percussion clef, which looks like this:

7

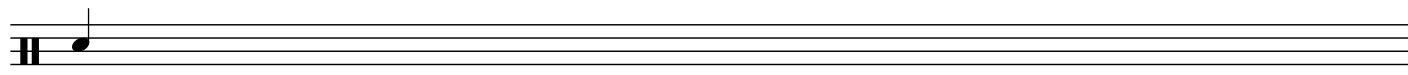


For now we only need to deal with the third space up from the bottom, the part of the staff where we write notes for the snare drum (more on this later).

What is a quarter note?

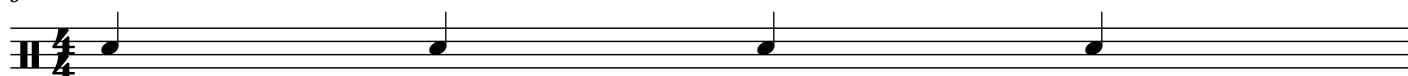
One of these!

8



Quarter notes tell us to *play the drum*. You can fit four of them into a **measure** of 4/4 time. Remember, the number on the bottom of our time signature tells us *how we are representing the pulse*. In 4/4 time we are using **quarter notes** to represent each **beat** of our **pulse**.

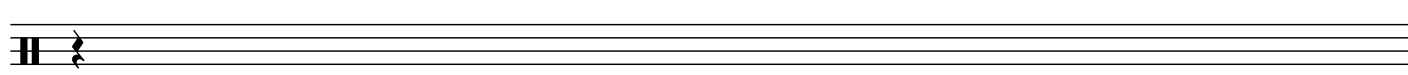
9



What is a quarter rest?

One of these!

10



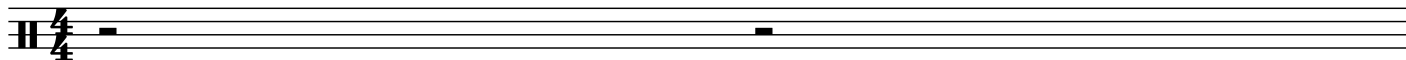
Quarter rests tell us *not to play*. They represent one **beat** of silence. We can fit four of them into a **measure** of 4/4 time, just like our quarter notes.

11



Half rests are similar. They represent two **beats** of silence, and we can fit two of them into a **measure** of 4/4 time.

12



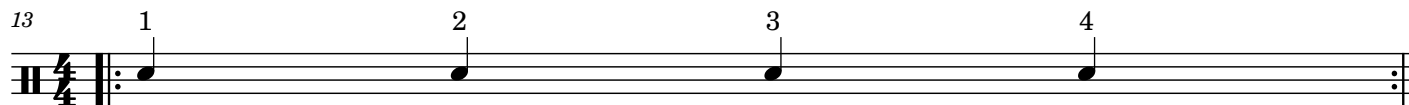
Putting It All Together

All of these concepts start to make sense when we combine them with the **metronome**. A metronome is like a clock you can hear. It ticks evenly, and each tick marks one **beat** of our **pulse**. In our first example below we will play every note right on top of the sound of the metronome! Notice the bar lines on this exercise are different: the double-line double-dot is a **repeat sign**. This tells us to play the pattern again. In the context of a set of exercises like these, the repeat signs tell us to play the pattern on loop until it is comfortable. Set your metronome to 60bpm with beat one accent turned on, or simply follow this link (and consider reading the first five sections of my guide on practicing with a metronome that can be found below the metronome interface).

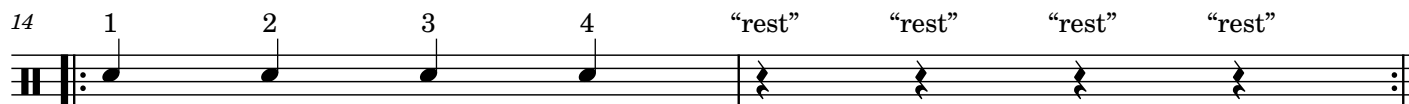
<https://jva-music.com/metronome/?bpm=60&beats=4&unit=4&p=ANNN>

As we do these exercises, it is useful to count out loud. It can be quite helpful to work through an exercise *just counting out loud without the instrument* before you try to play the example. Remember, there are four beats in each measure, and each quarter note is worth one beat, so all of our counts in this exercise should fall right on top of the sound of the metronome. In order to practice keeping time during our rests we can say “rest” out loud, (also with the metronome). Once for a quarter rest, twice for a half rest. When this starts to feel comfortable, try imagining you are saying “rest” instead of saying it out loud. Counts will be written in above the notes to help you.

In our first example, we play four notes right on top of the the sound of the metronome.



Here we play four notes right on top of the metronome, then let the metronome sound on its own for four **beats**.



4

In this example we play one note with the metronome, then let it sound on its own for one **beat**.

16 1 "rest" 3 "rest"

Now the opposite; first we let the metronome sound one **beat** alone, then we play with it.

17 "rest" 2 "rest" 4

The following examples will not include individual explanations.

18 1 2 3 "rest"

19 1 2 "rest--rest"

20 1 "rest" "rest--rest"

21 "rest--rest" "rest" 4

22 "rest--rest" 3 4

23 "rest" 2 3 4

24 1 "rest" 3 4

25 1 2 "rest" 4

26 1 "rest" "rest" 4

27 "rest" 2 3 "rest"

A major part of becoming a stronger reader of rhythms is **audiation**, which is the act of imagining a sound. The final section of this primer is a set of rhythms taken from three familiar nursery rhymes. Try to hear the melody in your head! Practicing **audiation** will help you internalize these concepts, and form connections between this lesson and music you are already familiar with. No counts included with these, but you can write them in yourself if you find the practice to be helpful.

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star

28

Twin - kle twin - kle lit - tle star how I won - der what you are.

Go Tell Aunt Rhody

32

Go tell aunt Rho - dy Go tell aunt Rho - o - dy

36

go tell aunt Rho - dy the old grey goose was fed.

Lightly Row

40

Light - ly row light - ly row o'er the shin - ing waves we go,

44

smooth - ly glide smooth - ly glide on the si - lent tide.